

# Fertilization

To make a baby, an egg must be fertilized by a sperm within 24 hours of being released from the ovary. Genetic information in the sperm and egg combine to form the full set of instructions needed to build a new human being.

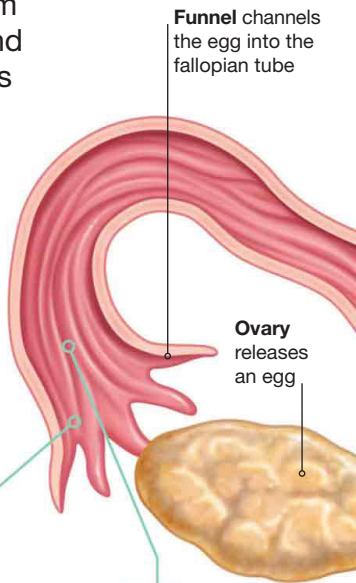
## Building cells

The fertilized egg travels to the uterus along a fallopian tube. As it does, the egg divides again and again. First, the single cell divides into two cells, then those two cells both divide, and so on. Eventually, the tiny ball of cells reaches the uterus, or womb, and settles in its lining.



**Fertilization** happens when a sperm penetrates the egg's outer layer (above), loses its tail, and fuses with the egg's nucleus.

About **36 hours** after fertilization, the egg divides to form two new cells. These continue to divide every 12 hours.



**Funnel** channels the egg into the fallopian tube

**Ovary** releases an egg